We followed up the victory at Chennai with a well-played draw at Mohali and won the series 1–0. Back-to-back series wins at home was an excellent way to cap off the year and we were all looking forward to our next away series in New Zealand.

Beating the Black Caps in New Zealand can be a tricky task, but we knew we had a great opportunity. We were in good form and seemed to have developed the useful ability to pull ourselves out of difficult situations; if one person failed, the second would step up.

In the five-match one-day series, we easily won the rain-affected first match, thanks largely to the batting of Sehwag and Dhoni. The second match was a washout, but in the third match at Christchurch, one of the smaller grounds, I had reached 163 when I was forced to retire hurt with a strained stomach muscle in the forty-fifth over.

It was frustrating to have to go off in that kind of form. I like to think I was in with a chance of scoring a double hundred had I been able to bat on, and I wasn't alone in thinking that. As soon as I entered the dressing room, Sehwag walked up to me, saying, '*Paaji yeh apne kya kar diya. Double hundred ka chance tha.*' (What have you done, brother? You had a realistic chance of scoring a double hundred.) I laughed and said to him, '*Arre main mar hi nahi pa raha hoon, double hundred kaise banaunga. Pitch achha hain aur hame abhi runs chaiye. Double hundred kabhi na kabhi ho jayga.*' (I can't even hit the ball, so how can I score a double hundred? It is a good pitch to bat on and we need big runs at the moment. I will score a double hundred at some point in the future.') Sehwag, however, wouldn't let up and said, '*Arre woh toh doosra double hundred hoga, aaj ka to aaj karna chaihiye tha!*' (When you score a double hundred again it might be the *second* double hundred. Today you should have scored the *first ever* ODI double ton!)

The match was a high-scoring one and, despite setting a target of 392, with Yuvraj Singh and Dhoni both making half-centuries, we were not safe. New Zealand played well to get to 334, thanks in no small part to an opening partnership of 166 between Brendon McCullum and Jesse Ryder, and the aggregate score of 726 in the two innings was the second highest in the history of ODI cricket.

I missed the next match at Hamilton, which we also won thanks to an onslaught from Sehwag that brought him 125. To celebrate taking a 3–0 lead in the series, Bhajji, Zaheer, Yuvi and I met up in Bhajji's room for dinner, which was next to the health club in the hotel. There was a